

can do higher studies in an area that interests you and get a job that you would love to do for free.

Sometimes, even when you have everything that qualifies you as the ideal candidate for a job, there could be many reasons why you might not get hired. For example, the IT industry might be in recession with all new recruitments frozen (it happened twice in the last decade). Or, it might be that you've not sent resumes to the right companies, where your skills will be valued. In the case of a recession, your options are limited. You can opt for higher studies or just wait longer for things to improve, using that time fruitfully to hone your existing skills or acquire new ones. In the second case, you need to network more and reach out to the right people.

In the figure, I've outlined various options that you have to improve your job prospects, using a 'mind-map'. Though the options in the diagram look obvious, I've seen that most freshers don't actually explore these options. Let me give you an example.

Recently, I suggested to a student that he try contributing to open source projects to improve his job prospects. He simply replied that it was not possible for him to do so. When I probed further, I found that he thought contributing to open source meant contributing to the Linux kernel (and he didn't have system programming skills in C)! That's a clear misconception – there are numerous open source projects, ranging from testing tools to messaging software. There is no dearth of opportunities to contribute in whatever topic or domain you're comfortable with. Even if you can test the software thoroughly and report bugs, that's a contribution to the open source community. So, don't limit yourself when exploring the options before you.

Take this mind-map image as a tool for brainstorming about which options will work best for you. For example, getting the relevant certification is certainly one of the best

ways to boost your job prospects. While certifications don't assure you a job, there are many advantages in getting certified. First, it distinguishes you from the rest of the crowd. Second, the interviewers can clearly see you as prepared and more focused than other candidates. Third, for yourself, preparing for certification gives you a focus and passing the test will give you a sense of achievement, which in turn improves your confidence. For these reasons, it is better to get certified.

Believe me: searching for a job can be a memorable experience, if done in the right way. You have the freedom and time to explore what you like and can spend more time with family and friends. If you approach the task of searching for a job with a positive attitude and take it as a challenge, you'll come out as a stronger person no matter whether you get the job or not. Research findings show that human beings are happiest when they challenge themselves, stretch their limits and explore new ideas and possibilities.

Finally, here's a warning. I've seen many freshers going the wrong way when they meet a dead-end and don't get a job for a few years. For example, some pay to get fake experience certificates. Don't do that. You might end up getting a job that shows you have prior experience. But in the long run, this might embolden you to take bigger risks and make mistakes with more serious repercussions. That could land you in situations that you'll have enormous difficulties recovering from.

Believe in hard work, be honest, prepare well and give your best, and I am sure you will land a good job (sooner or later). 

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MONTH	THEME	FEATURED LIST
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June 2012	Android	Virtualisation Solution Providers
July 2012	Open Source in Medicine	Web Hosting Providers
August 2012	Open Source on Windows	Top Tablets
September 2012	Open Source on Mac	Top Smart Phones
October 2012	Kernel Development	CLOUD Solution Providers
November 2012	Open Source Businesses	Android Solution Providers
December 2012	Linux & Open Source Powered Network Security	Network Security Solutions Providers
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